

THOMAS SOPWITH

BRITISH AIRCRAFT MANUFACTURER Thomas Octave Murdoch (TOM) Sopwith (1888–1989) had a relentless appetite for sports and machines. Learning to fly in 1910, he crashed on his first solo flight, but went on to become one of Britain's top sporting pilots.

In 1912, he set up the Sopwith Aviation Company, producing a string of successful aircraft including the *Bat Boat* (Britain's first successful flying boat), the *Tabloid* Seaplane (the first British airplane to win the prestigious Schneider trophy), and numerous fighter planes during World War I.

COMPANY FOUNDER

As a young man, Thomas Sopwith's taste for sport (ballooning and sailing) and his engineering skills (indulged on cars and motorcycles) led him to aviation.



take the lead again until the late 1920s.

Americans did play a prominent part in taking aircraft to sea, but even then they cannot claim to have created the first seaplane.

Early seaplanes

That honor belongs to French engineer, Henri Fabre, whose Gnome-powered seaplane made the first flights from water in March 1910 (see below). The first truly practical seaplane, however, was tested by Curtiss in 1911, when the Curtiss-Ellyson "hydroplane" took off from San Diego Bay, California. Curtiss achieved another first in 1912 by designing a flying boat – that is, an aircraft resting in the water on a boatlike hull, rather than on floats. Manufacturers on the other side of the Atlantic, including Short Brothers and Sopwith, soon joined in with their own seaplanes and flying boats, and, in 1912, the first seaplane meeting was held at Monaco.

During this period, and for several decades to come, seaplanes and flying boats had several clear advantages over land-planes. The oceans provided an almost limitless space for takeoff and landing at a time when airfields were limited. This not only meant that seaplanes and flying boats could operate where aerodromes did not exist, but also that they could potentially be larger and faster than land-planes.

Mail and passengers

One area in which the advantage of speed outweighed the disadvantage of a limited payload was in mail delivery. From 1911, exhibition airmail flights were frequently arranged in connection with an airshow or other event, and financed by the sale of souvenir postcards or franked envelopes. Surprisingly, the first such flight took place in Allahabad in British-ruled India in January 1911. Later in the year, exhibition airmail flights were authorized in Britain, France, Germany, and the United States. Claude Grahame-White's Aviation Company carried 130,000 letters and cards between Hendon and Windsor, in England, during



FIRST NAVAL TAKEOFF

On November 14, 1910, American pilot Eugene Ely's demonstration sparks off the US Navy's interest in flight. Flying a Curtiss pusher, Ely successfully took off from a wooden platform on the cruiser USS Birmingham, in Hampton Roads, Virginia.

